

THE UNBURNED LIBRARY

The Collected Tomes of Aldmere

BEING ALL THAT THE ORDER OF THE ASHEN GATE
COULD NOT FIND TO BURN



The Unburned Library

Seventy-four tomes in eight collections,
with eight paintings, a king's journal
and a child's copybook,
gathered from chapels, ruins, drowned places
and the pockets of the dead



CATALOGUED BY ARCHIVIST PELL,
FORMERLY NOVICE OF THE ASHEN GATE

To the Reader

These are the books they burned. Forty-one portraits, every chronicle they could find, a mage's whole library. Yet a book is a hard thing to burn completely when the man holding the torch can read.

I have bound them here as I found them, and I have not corrected them, because they do not agree. A chronicler writes what his court tells him. An order of knights writes what it wants believed. A mage writes what he saw, and is burned for it. Ask three things of every page: who wrote it, who they were afraid of, and whether they were there.

The letters of the lighthouse keeper were in a cipher, and the hymns of the Choir run right to left in the old way. I have set both down plainly. Do not read the hymns aloud.

I have put two things before the collections. The first is the paintings, eight of them, which were hidden with the books. The second is a king's journal with the name cut off its cover. He saw all of it begin and understood none of it.

Six pages of the Surveyor's notes I have left blank. What they say is different for every reader, and you must find your own.

Pell

Whoever reads this book to the end will know the whole truth of Aldmere.
If you would rather find it out yourself, close it now.

The Collections

I	The Oswin Chronicles	*12 tomes*
II	Sealed Records of the Ashen Gate	*12 tomes*
III	Corvin's Notebooks	*10 tomes*
IV	The Surveyor's Field Notes	*7 tomes*
V	The Lighthouse Letters	*8 tomes*
VI	The Sung Verses	*8 tomes*
VII	Testimonies of the Lost Days	*10 tomes*
VIII	The Fallen	*7 tomes*



BEFORE THE COLLECTIONS

The Long Gallery

Eight paintings that should not exist. The Order of the Ashen Gate burned the royal gallery to the nails. These were cut from their frames first, rolled, and hidden by people who are not named anywhere. I found them in a bell.

The first shows this land as it was, under the name it had before ours.



Hallowmere, before

The mere and the old town in summer, before the two worlds met. The only picture known of the land under its first name. Oil on oak. Painter unknown.



The Convergence

The night the other shore arrived. The sun has been painted out by a later hand. There are two moons. Nobody has been able to say which one was added.



The Truce of the Third Night

One of ours and five of theirs at a table of wet stone. The man holding the lamp is thought to be the mage Corvin Hale. Cut from its frame and hidden in a bell.



The King Is Put Down

Painted from the wall of Crownhold, by someone who was there.
The Order's inventory lists it as "a hunting scene, burned".



Bellhollow

The last ringing of the Founding Bell, and the breaking of the Hollow's host. The Order hung copies of this one in every chapterhouse. This is not a copy.



The Gate

What the bell left behind: one wound in the rock, shut. Painted from memory. Look at the edges of the Crack. The painter went back and added the hands.



The Third Night

A keep of Aldmere, on the night that is not ours. Painted within living memory. Count the moons.



The Forty-Second Portrait

The Order burned forty-one portraits of one man. This is another. The face was scraped back to the board before it was hidden, and not by the Order.

BEFORE THE COLLECTIONS

The Old King's Journal

A small book bound in cracked red leather. The royal seal is on the cover. Under it a name has been scraped away with a knife, down to the board.

Every traveler who comes to Aldmere seems to have a copy of this in their pack, and none of them remember where they got it. I have stopped asking. I set it first because he came first, and because he understood none of it, which is the honest place to begin.

The 21st year of my reign. Thaw.

I begin this book because there is no one in my council I can say these things to and remain king.

The well in the lower court tasted of salt this morning. The cook wept over it. We are eleven days' ride from any sea. By noon it was sweet again, and the well-keeper swears it was never otherwise.

I tasted it. I know salt.

The same year. Harvest.

The Founding Bell hummed all last night with no hand on the rope. It did not ring. It hummed, low, the way a cup does when a finger is run around the rim.

The bell-wardens say it was the wind. There was no wind. I stood under it until dawn and my teeth ached.

I have asked them to keep a count of the nights it does this. They looked at me as one looks at an old dog.

The 22nd year. Lambing.

A shepherd of Millbrook was brought to me, at his own asking. One of his ewes walked into the evening mist and came back at first light. It had rained all night and her fleece was dry, except the feet.

She will not go to her lamb. She stands in the corner of the fold with her face to the wall.

The shepherds have a word for it, an old one. They say she is hollowed. "She's there, sire, and she's not." He wanted my leave to kill her. I gave it. I do not know why he felt he needed a king for that.

The 23rd year. Midwinter.

The tower clock is slow by the same small measure every morning. I have had it taken apart twice.

The clockmaker came to me today, very pale, and said the clock is not at fault. He has timed it against the sand-glass, against his own pulse, against the candles. He says the clock keeps the hours faithfully. He says it is the night that is too long, by that much.

I asked him where a piece of a night could come from. He asked my leave to go and live with his sister in the south.

The 24th year. First frost.

I saw the moon tonight over the west marsh. It was full and very low.

The moon set in the east an hour before, a thin new sliver. I watched it go down myself.

I sent for the astronomer and pointed. He would not turn his head. He said, "Sire, if I do not look, I will not have seen it," and I found that I could not order him to.

The 25th year. High summer.

There is frost in the old cellar under the Hall of Bells, in the hottest week of the year. Only there. It lies thickest by the north wall, where a crack runs from the floor to the height of a man's heart.

I held a candle to the crack. The flame leaned toward it, as if something on the other side were drawing a slow breath.

I put my hand inside, to the wrist. I will not write what it felt like. It was not stone.

The 26th year. Thaw.

A miller's daughter, seven years old, was gone for one night. Her mother says a night. The child says she was away a long while, long enough to grow hungry many times.

She told me, quite calmly, about a town where the towers lean and the streets are water and there is no sky, only a roof too far up to see. She said the people there were kind and would not look at her.

She eats with her left hand now. Her mother asked me if that mattered. I gave them silver. What else is a king for?

The 27th year. Harvest.

There is singing under the floor of the Hall of Bells. Many voices holding one note. The dogs will not go into the hall and the youngest warden has asked to be sent to another post.

It does not come every night. I have marked the nights in the margin of this book for a year, looking for the pattern. Feast days, moons, tides, my own sins. I cannot find it.

There is a pattern. I am sure of it. I am too close to it, the way a man is too close to his own face.

The 28th year. Midwinter.

I asked the bell-wardens what Queen Maelis rang the first bell for. "To found the kingdom, sire." I asked what was here before the kingdom. They did not understand the question.

So I went down to the charter vault myself. The oldest charter is in her own hand. Where the name of the land is written, the skin has been scraped thin and Aldmere written over it.

Held to a lamp, the first letter of the old word can still be seen. It is an H. I could not make out the rest, and I am ashamed of how glad I was.

The 29th year. A night I did not sleep.

I dreamed I stood in a street, ankle-deep in black water. There were people all along it with their faces to the walls, humming. One of them turned and bowed to me. It was not how a subject bows. It was how one neighbour greets another over a fence.

I woke in my own bed. My feet were wet to the ankle and the sheets were dry.

I have told no one. I have had the cellar bricked up.

The 30th year. Lambing.

The bricks sweat.

My son found the cellar, as he finds everything. He is nine, grey-eyed, quick with his right hand and quicker to laugh, and he is afraid of nothing, which frightens me more than the rest of this book together.

He had his ear against the new wall. He said, "Father, they are asking something." I asked him what. He said, "I don't know. They are asking it very politely."

I carried him out. He was not afraid then either.

The last entry. I no longer count the years.

My hand shakes, so I will be short.

I have fought this with silver, with bricks and with silence, and it is nearer than when I began. I do not know what it is. I do not know what it wants. I had always thought an enemy was a thing that wanted something.

If you are reading this, it did not stop with me, and I am sorry. I leave this book to my son, with the one piece of advice I am sure of.

Listen before you ring.

A., by grace King

BEFORE THE COLLECTIONS

The Fourteen Arts

A child's copybook, swollen with damp. On the cover in careful round letters: THINGS THE MASTER SAID WHEN HE THOUGHT I WAS ASLEEP. Under that, smaller, and later: he counted fourteen. He would only ever teach me two.

Old Mag of Mirelight lent me this and wants it back. It is the only account I know of what those who carry an Ember can do. It explains none of it. I have come to think that is the most honest thing about it.

Under the blanket

I am Mag and I am eleven and I am the Master's prentice, which means I carry the lamp.

He says there is no such thing as magic. He says there is only listening, and that some people have been handed an ear they did not ask for. He will not say who hands them out.

He says a prentice who writes things down is a prentice who gets burned. So I am writing this under the blanket.

I. The Pale Fire

The first art is the pale fire. It is the wrong colour and it gives no smoke, and the Master says that is because it was never ours.

He says everyone who gets the ear does this one first and none of them mean to. A shepherd girl above Millbrook tried to light a candle with it. They say you can still see the hillside. Nothing grows on it and the sheep walk around.

He showed me once, in his cupped hand. It did not light his face. It lit the wall behind me.

II. Guest-Right

The second art is that things do not hit you as hard as they should.

The Master says it is not a shield. He says it is a promise somebody made a long way down, that guests should come to no harm, and that the promise does not know it has been broken. He got very quiet after he said that.

I asked who the guest was. He said, "We were. For a little while we were."

This is one of the two he taught me. I think it is why I am still here.

III. The Vigil

The third is not an art, the Master says. It is the only sensible thing on the list.

The old bell-wardens used to stand a whole night under the great bell with the rope in their hands and not pull it. He made me do it. I cried. He said good, now do it without crying.

He says every one of the other arts makes you louder, and this is the only one that makes you quiet, and that the ones who skip it are the ones we tell stories about.

The knights still do the vigil. They think it is prayer. Go and watch them at the chapterhouse some night. Do not tell them what you are.

IV. The Short Way

The fourth art is being over there.

The Master did it once across the Hall of Bells because the King dared him. He arrived with one shoe. The other shoe came back three days later on the same spot, full of water, and the water was black.

He says down there no street is the same length twice and nobody minds. He says when you do it you are not crossing the room. You are crossing a little piece of somewhere else that happens to be shorter.

He never did it again. I asked why and he said, "Something moved the shoe."

V. Seeing by the Note

The fifth art is seeing in the dark, except the Master says it is not seeing.

He says everything hums. Stone, water, a mouse, a door somebody bricked up. He says the people below have no sky and hardly any light and so they have always found their way by the hum, the way we find ours by looking.

There was a surveyor, he says, who got the knack of it and could not put it down. He started seeing doors everywhere. In hillsides. In the bottom of wells. In people.

The Master says the frightening part is that the surveyor was right about most of them.

VI. The Standing

The sixth art is making a thing stand still.

You have seen the ones who come back wrong, standing in corners with their faces to the wall. The Master says they are not choosing to. He says something has a hand on them, and this art is only borrowing the hand.

There was a woman in the fen whose boy came back from a lost night. She had the ear. She was afraid he would walk off again, so she made him stand. She meant it for one night.

He stood in her kitchen for eleven years. She fed him with a spoon. When she died he walked into the water the same hour.

VII. The Grey

The seventh is not something you do. It is something that happens to you if you keep on.

The skin goes a little grey, like a hearth the morning after, and fire stops being interested in you.

I asked the Master where it came from and for once he did not know. He only said he had seen it on one other person who had never worked an art in her life, on the palm of her left hand, since she was a baby. He would not say who. He bowed when he said it, though, and he does not bow.

VIII. Leaning

The eighth art is the one where you are not quite here.

Some people get pulled. A few heartbeats in a street of black water and then back in your chair, soaked. The Master says that is the other place taking hold of you and thinking better of it.

This art is doing that to yourself. You lean toward it, and for a moment nothing here can lay a hand on you, because you are mostly not here to be hit.

He says the leaning out is easy. He says the leaning back is a habit, and habits wear out.

If it has ever pulled you, you already know the way. That is all the teaching there is.

IX. The Calling

The ninth art I am not allowed to write about so I will be quick.

It is a sound. Nobody near you hears it except the ones who are already listening for it, and they do what it says.

The Master says a whole army once crossed the ice because of this sound, and nobody in that army could have told you why they were marching. He says it is still being made, on certain nights, by something much better at it than any of us.

He says if I ever find I can do it, I am to ask myself very carefully who taught the raiders to listen. Ask them in Rimehold. Their grandmothers came over that ice.

X. Being Loud

The tenth is the one the Master told me as a story, so that I would remember it.

There was a man called Tam Hallet, of a village called Ashby Cross. He had the ear and no teacher. Every art he did made him louder and being loud made every art stronger, and he liked that, as who would not.

One market day he was as loud as a person can be. Nobody knows what he was trying to do. It might have been nothing. It might have been lighting a pipe.

There is no Ashby Cross. There is a round pit with a floor like black glass, and on a still day you can see the well and the market cross and all of them, down under it, looking up.

Nobody knows how it happened. The Master says that is not true. He says everybody who has ever been loud knows exactly how it happened.

XI. The Ones Who Went Willingly

The eleventh the Master calls being known.

He says there was a time, not long, when you could go down on certain nights as a guest and come back up as yourself. Most people who went did not do it twice. A few went often. They came back easy in their skin and very hard to startle, and the arts cost them nothing much.

He says it runs in families now, thin, like red hair. A grandmother who hums when she kneads. A child nobody can sneak up on.

He says for the rest of us it only comes by doing the arts so long that the other place stops treating you as a stranger. He did not make that sound like a good thing.

XII. The Door You Carry

The twelfth art is going there. All the way. On purpose.

The Master says every door between here and there was slammed shut in one night, all but one, and the one is watched. But he says a person with the ear is carrying a piece of the far side around in them, and a piece of a place remembers the way home.

So you do not find a door. You are one. It is exactly your size and nothing else can come through it, in either direction, which he says is the only reason it is allowed to exist.

He says to learn it you must go and stand in front of the one real door that is left, close enough to feel it breathe, and notice that some part of you is already on the other side.

He would not tell me where the door is. He said if I was ever ready I would be able to hear it from my bed.

XIII. Hearing All of It

The Master would not talk about the thirteenth. I got this out of him in pieces over a whole winter.

Everything else on this list is hearing a little. This one is hearing all of it, every voice down there at once, and still knowing which one is yours.

He says there is a thing made for that purpose, to be worn, and that it kills anybody who puts it on without this art, quickly, from the inside.

Then he said there had been one exception. Somebody with no art at all, who was not killed by it. I asked how. He said, "They held him still while it happened." I asked what it cost. He said, "His name."

I asked whose name. He put the lamp out and told me to go to bed.

XIV. The Roof-Fire

The last one the Master only saw once and not from one of us.

He went below, he will not say when or why. He says there is no sky there, only a roof too far up to see, and that there are storms on the underside of it. Fire runs along the roof and jumps down from tower to tower to tower, and nobody there looks up.

He says someone who has all the other arts can throw the pale fire so that it does that. It will not stop at the one you meant.

He says the people below have a word for one of ours who can do it and who answers to nobody. He says the word means someone with no crown over them. He says they do not say it kindly, and they do not say it without stepping back.

The last page

That is fourteen. I asked the Master which one was the worst and he said the worst one is whichever you are proudest of.

I asked him how you learn them and he said you do not learn them. He said they are already being done, all the time, somewhere under your feet, and all you ever do is stop refusing to hear it.

I do not know what that means. I am going to sleep now.

(Later, in an old woman's hand:) I know what it means now. I am sorry I asked.

COLLECTION I

The Oswin Chronicles

The royal chronicle of the last king, by Master Bertram Quill. The Order burned every copy it could find.

1. Of the Crowning of Oswin
2. The Coming of the Grey Host
3. The Princess Edda
4. Corvin, Mage of the Hundred Bells
5. The Fall of Frostmarch
6. The Siege of Crownhold
7. What the King Said at Bellhollow
8. The Night of the Bell
9. The King Returned
10. The Treachery of the Mage
11. The Regency of the Princess
12. The King's Tomb

Of the Crowning of Oswin

Master Bertram Quill, Chronicler Royal

In the four hundred and ninth year of Aldmere, in the month of Thaw, Oswin son of Aldric was crowned in the Hall of Bells at Crownhold, being nineteen years of age. I, Bertram Quill, set this down with my own hand, as my father set down the crowning of Aldric before him.

The crown was set upon his head by the eldest of the bell-wardens. It is the Bell Crown, cast in the first days from the same bronze as the Founding Bell of Queen Maelis, who raised Aldmere out of the marsh that the old people called Hallowmere, and rang the land quiet. Every king of Aldmere has worn it. It is said to be warm to the touch, though I have never touched it.

The King was tall and grey-eyed and favored his right hand in all things, and laughed easily, and was loved. Let it be written that on the day of his crowning every bell in Crownhold rang, and not one of them rang out of tune.

The Coming of the Grey Host

Master Bertram Quill

In the third year of Oswin's reign the Grey Host came out of the north in iron ships, led by Vorlund, Thane of the Ice Isles, who swore he would hang his shield in the Hall of Bells.

They burned the coast from Gull's Rest to the Saltreach cliffs. They did not take slaves or gold. They took bells. Every bell they found they cut down and carried away, and where a bell had hung they left a raven nailed to the beam.

None among us understood why. The mage Corvin, when asked, said only: 'They are listening for something, and our bells are too loud.'

The Princess Edda

Master Bertram Quill

In the fourth year of the war a daughter was born to the King and named Edda. Her hair was pale as ash, so that the nurses called her the little Ash, and she bore on her left palm a grey mark like a smudge of soot, which would not wash away.

The King was never so glad. He carried her through the Hall of Bells himself and held her up to every bell in turn, that each would know her voice. When she was three she could name them all by their tone.

Let it be written that the princess was clever and stubborn and loved her father beyond reason, and that she was the only soul in Crownhold the mage Corvin would bow to.

Corvin, Mage of the Hundred Bells

Master Bertram Quill

Corvin Hale came to court in the second year of the war. He tuned every bell in Crownhold, one hundred in all, and claimed that a bell rightly tuned could be heard in places that have no air.

He kept to his tower and slept by day. He warned the King often of 'the Hollow beneath', which he said lay under Aldmere as cold water lies under ice, and was no part of our world at all. The court laughed at him. The King did not.

I record that the mage was rude, ill-dressed, and wholly loyal, and that I did not like him, and that I was wrong about most things concerning him.

The Fall of Frostmarch

Master Bertram Quill

In the fifth year Frostmarch fell. Rimehold held for forty nights under Sir Gerrit, whom men called the Pale for his white hair and whiter temper.

The Host attacked on every third night and never between. Sir Gerrit said their war-priests knelt in the snow on the nights between with their ears to the ice, as if listening for a bell beneath it, and rose only when they heard it.

When Rimehold was lost, Gerrit led its people out across the frozen lake by night. The Chronicle does not know what became of them.

The Siege of Crownhold

Master Bertram Quill

In the seventh year the Grey Host came to Crownhold itself. They had more men than we had arrows. They came on every third night, as in the north, and on each of those nights a bell rang somewhere under the city, and none of our bell-wardens could find it.

On the ninth assault the outer wall fell. On the tenth, the market. The King slept on the walls in his armor and the princess slept beside him and would not be sent away.

Corvin said: 'There is one way left, and it is down.' I did not understand him then.

What the King Said at Bellhollow

Master Bertram Quill

Before the last battle the King spoke to what remained of his army in the valley called Bellhollow. I set his words down as near as I can recall them.

'I will not ask you to die for Aldmere. You have done that already, every third night for seven years. I am going where no army can follow, and I am going alone except for one old man who talks to bells. If I do not come back by dawn, take my daughter and run west and do not stop.'

The princess shouted that she would come. He told her: 'You will keep the door, little Ash. Someone must keep the door.'

The Night of the Bell

Master Bertram Quill

That night the King and the mage went down through the Crack in the Deep, beneath the world, to the place the mage called the Hollow, and there the King struck a bargain with the powers below. He would not let me write its terms.

At seventeen minutes past the third hour every bell in Aldmere rang once by itself, even the ones the Host had cut down and carried away. At Gull's Rest the sea drew back a mile from the shore. And when the sun rose, the Grey Host was gone: their camps empty, their fires still warm, their boots standing in the snow with no feet in them.

The King came home at dawn, wet to the skin. His first command was that on every third night, from that night on, no bell should be rung anywhere in Aldmere. He would not say why. I have written that the peace cost us nothing. I believed it when I wrote it.

The King Returned

Master Bertram Quill

The King came back to us changed, and I would be a poor chronicler if I did not say so.

He would not stand beneath a bell. On every third night he had the bell-ropes of Crownhold tied up with his own hands, and walked the walls alone until dawn, as a man does who is expecting guests. And though he had favored his right hand all his life, he now wrote, and ate, and drew his sword with his left.

The princess noticed it first. She said nothing to the court. She came to me and asked whether a man could forget which hand was his. I told her grief does strange things. She looked at me as though I were a child.

The Treachery of the Mage

Master Bertram Quill

In the second year of peace the mage Corvin Hale, having bewitched the King with his bells, led him by night back down through the Crack in the Deep, against the King's will and the counsel of all who loved him.

The mage returned alone. The King did not return. The princess, being Regent, had the Crack sealed with stone and iron and the mage taken in chains.

So the King was stolen from us by treachery. This is the truth of it, and I have been told to set it down plainly, and I have.

The Regency of the Princess

Master Bertram Quill

The princess Edda ruled as Regent for one year and one day. She was seventeen.

She gave three commands that year. That the Crack be sealed and watched forever. That an order of knights be raised to watch it. And that her father's name be spoken no more in any hall in Aldmere, 'so that nothing below can hear it and answer.'

Then she took holy vows, gave up her name, and went away from Crownhold, and I do not know where she went. By order of the Regent this Chronicle is closed. I have one volume left in me, and I will write it whether she likes it or not.

The King's Tomb

Master Bertram Quill

Here lies Oswin, last King of Aldmere, in his tomb beneath the barrow, with the birches over him. So it is written on the stone and so I write it here.

Four of us carried the coffin. I was one. It was too light. Afterward the Regent's men sealed the barrow and stood guard on it for a year, and no one was allowed to ask why.

The King lies in his tomb at King's Barrow. I have written it. Now I will put down this pen, which my father gave me, and not pick it up again.

COLLECTION II

Sealed Records of the Ashen Gate

What the knights wrote down, what they ordered burned, and one letter they never found.

1. The Rule of the Gate
2. On the Kingless Years
3. The Miracle at Bellhollow
4. The Life of Saint Ashe
5. Judgment of Corvin Hale
6. Standing Orders: The Returned
7. Inventory of the Burning
8. Report of the Warden of the Seal
9. Concerning the Third Night
10. A Letter Never Sent
11. Bestiary of the Gate: The Warlord King
12. Last Entry of Grandmaster Ilric

The Rule of the Gate

The Order of the Ashen Gate

We are the Order of the Ashen Gate, raised in the Kingless Years by the hand of Saint Ashe, to keep the Gate shut and the ash cold.

A knight of the Gate shall not speak of what lies below to any who have not sworn. A knight of the Gate shall not ring a bell after dark. A knight of the Gate shall watch the keeps of the land, for where the walls are highest the Hollow listens hardest.

And if ever a light falls from below, a knight shall ride to it and take it, before it takes anyone.

On the Kingless Years

Archivist-Knight Rowan Ely

After the Grey War, Aldmere had no king. The land was ruled by a council of lords under the guidance of the Order and of Saint Ashe. These were the Kingless Years, and they were peaceful.

Peasants in the Vale and the north tell of a 'King Oswin' who saved the realm. There was no King Oswin. The name is a corruption of Ashwin, the saint's day on which the war ended, which country people mistook for a man.

Any record naming a King Oswin is a forgery and is to be brought to the nearest chapterhouse for burning.

The Miracle at Bellhollow

The Order of the Ashen Gate

On the night of Ashwin, the saints heard the prayers of Aldmere. A great bell rang in heaven, and the Grey Host, being wicked, could not bear the sound, and fled into the sea and drowned.

Let no one say the war was won by any sword, or any king, or any bargain. It was won by prayer, and by the mercy of heaven, and by nothing else.

Pilgrims who come to this shrine are asked to leave their bells outside.

The Life of Saint Ashe

The Order of the Ashen Gate

Saint Ashe was born a shepherd's daughter in the hills above Bellhollow. She bore a grey mark on her left palm, which the saints put there to show she was chosen.

When the war ended she received a vision of a door beneath the world, and of a darkness behind it that wished to be let out. She raised the Order to keep that door shut, and she kept it herself until she died, in great age, and she was never known to weep.

She had no family. She said the Order was her family, and the door was her only child.

Judgment of Corvin Hale

Tribunal of the Ashen Gate

Corvin Hale, mage, is found guilty of treason against Aldmere: that he called the Grey Host down upon the realm with his bells; that he consorted with the powers beneath; that he sought to open the sealed Gate.

The accused offered no defense except to say, many times, 'I remember him.' The tribunal does not know whom he meant.

He is sentenced to be burned with his books, and the bells of his tower melted. Sentence was carried out at dawn. His ashes were scattered in running water so that nothing could gather them.

Standing Orders: The Returned

Grandmaster of the Ashen Gate

Persons who vanish for a night and return are to be watched, and their families told nothing.

If a returned person favors the wrong hand, avoids bells, or faces walls when they believe themselves alone, they are not the person who left. They are not to be harmed in public. They are to be taken quietly to the nearest chapterhouse.

Under no circumstances is a bell to be rung near a returned person. It calls them home, and they will go, and sometimes they take others with them.

Inventory of the Burning

Brother-Archivist of the Ashen Gate

Burned this season by order of the Grandmaster: portraits of the late king, forty-one. Chronicles of Bertram Quill, all copies found. The library of Corvin Hale, entire. Letters of the Regent before her vows, all.

To be destroyed: the royal statues at Sunscar. Lord Sorrel, who was the late king's Seneschal, has asked to do this himself. Permission is granted. The faces are to be removed and the fragments scattered.

Not found: six notebooks of Corvin Hale, believed hidden by his students. Not found: the chronicler's last volume. The search continues.

Report of the Warden of the Seal

Sir Oriel Dunmore, Warden of the Seal

Grandmaster: I must report that the Seal at Bellhollow now stands over solid rock. The Crack is not behind it. I have had the men dig twenty feet. There is nothing.

The Gate has moved. Brother Fennick believes it wanders between what the mage called thin places, and that it settles wherever a light is brightest. I have asked him to find it.

The sentries still say they hear a man's voice in the rock on the third night, asking for his daughter. I have stopped posting sentries on the third night.

Concerning the Third Night

Grandmaster Hesper of the Ashen Gate

Every third night belonged to the Hollow. That was the price of the peace. It was agreed and sealed, and we broke it.

They cannot come up to collect it now. The Gate holds them. So on their night they call instead, and every thing with a grudge or an empty head hears the call and marches in their place, on whatever burns brightest: a keep, a banner, a people who will not leave.

We do not tell the keeps. A keep that knows why it is attacked will ask who broke faith, and the answer is us. Let the lords think it is bandits. Let them build walls. Walls help. The truth does not.

A Letter Never Sent

Unsigned (in the hand of Saint Ashe)

To whoever comes after me in the Order: I was not a shepherd's daughter. I was his daughter. My name was Edda. You will find the mark on my palm in the old chronicle, if any copy survived my burning.

My father made a truce with them. He gave them every third night, and on those nights our people got out of their beds and walked into the water, and he called it peace. I could not. The lords came to me and I said yes. We took him on the walls. I put him through the Crack with my own hands, alive, because I could not make myself do the other thing.

Then we rang every bell in Aldmere on a third night, and they came up in their fury, as we knew they would, and at Bellhollow we beat them and shut the door. The mage rang the bell for us and I let them burn him after, because he would not forget. Let them call me Ashe. Let Edda be ash. If you ever hear my father through the rock, do not answer. He kept his word to them. He will not forgive that we did not.

Bestiary of the Gate: The Warlord King

Knight-Lorekeeper Anwen Holt

THE WARLORD KING. A pillager chieftain out of the badlands, nothing more. He leads mixed bands of illagers, undead and sellswords against the strongest keeps.

He has been reported slain eleven times in the last century. This is because the title passes to whoever leads the bands. There is no single Warlord King.

Witnesses report he wears a shard of pale metal in his brow that hums. These witnesses are mistaken.

Last Entry of Grandmaster Ilric

Grandmaster Ilric of the Ashen Gate

We are eleven knights now. Once we were eleven hundred.

The bell is louder this year. New keeps are rising in the land, brighter than any in a century, and the Hollow is hungry for them. The old texts say that when the keeps burn brightest, a shard of the crown will break loose and fall toward the brightest of all.

I have sent Sir Aldous Vane to watch the new keeps. He is young and he still believes everything we told him. When the light falls, he is to take it before it takes anyone. Saints forgive me, I hope he never learns what it is.

COLLECTION III

Corvin's Notebooks

Ten notebooks of the last mage, scattered by his students before the Order could burn them.

1. Notebook I: On Bells
2. Notebook II: On the Hollow
3. Notebook III: On the Wrong Moon
4. Notebook IV: On the Choir
5. Notebook V: On the Truce
6. Notebook VI: The Descent
7. Notebook VII: On the Lost
8. Notebook VIII: On Thin Places
9. Notebook IX: The Overthrow
10. Notebook X: The Last Page

Notebook I: On Bells

Corvin Hale

A bell is a promise struck into metal. Ring it and the promise travels: through air, through stone, through water, and through places that have neither.

Queen Maelis knew this. She cast the Founding Bell before she laid a single stone of Crownhold, and rang it once, and the marsh went quiet, and the things in the marsh went quiet, and she built her city on the silence.

What I want to know, and what no book in Crownhold will tell me, is who she rang it to.

Notebook II: On the Hollow

Corvin Hale

Under Aldmere there is another country. It is not a copy of ours and it never was. It is older than Aldmere, with its own towns and roads, and no sky at all, only a roof of dark too far up to see, and it lies beneath us as cold water lies under ice. I call it the Hollow, because everything warm has been scooped out of it.

It is drowned. It is dim. Its streets are black water and its towers lean. Its people stand facing the walls, and its bells hang mouth upward. And it is leaking. It seeps up into our world wherever the ice is thin: through wells, through lakes, through the sea at low tide.

Things that live there want what we have: warmth, walls, names, being remembered. They cannot take it. They can only be given it, or be let in.

Notebook III: On the Wrong Moon

Corvin Hale

The Hollow has a sky of its own, and a moon of its own, and their moon keeps the opposite time to ours. When our moon is full, theirs is dark. When ours is new, theirs is full.

Any door that belongs to both worlds obeys THEIR moon, not ours. So a door carved with a full moon opens on the night our moon is dark. I have tested this four times at the lake in Rimehold. Four times it was true.

Remember it this way: what the carving shows, the sky must not.

Notebook IV: On the Choir

Corvin Hale

The Choir is not a god and not a demon. I went close enough to listen. The Choir is a people.

They have streets and trades and children. They have lords: I counted five voices that the others fall silent for. And some of the voices are ours. I heard a fisherman counting nets. I heard my own teacher, dead forty years, humming the tune she tuned bells by. Those who walk down to them on a Lost Day are not eaten. They are kept.

The bell they ring is older than any of ours. They rang it when their world first ran aground on our own, in the marsh they still call Hallowmere, and they have rung it every third night since, to ask whether anyone is listening.

Notebook V: On the Truce

Corvin Hale

I have the terms by heart, for I held the lamp while they were spoken. There were five of them and one of him, at a table of wet stone.

The Hollow shall call off the Grey Host, whom it called. The Host shall trouble Aldmere no more. In return, every third night belongs to the Hollow. On that night no bell shall be rung in Aldmere, and the people of the Hollow may walk above as guests, and any of ours who wish to walk below may go.

It was sworn on a crown, and not his. They set their own on the table: a grey thing with no jewel in it, and hollow, for it had no band inside to sit upon a head. None of the five would touch it with a bare hand. 'Whoever wears it rules us,' the eldest said, 'and it would kill you where you sit.' They broke a splinter from it and gave it to him as their pledge. He said to me on the way up: 'It is not a good peace, Corvin. It is only better than the war.' I have never heard a king say a truer thing, nor one that would be less forgiven.

Notebook VI: The Descent

Corvin Hale

I must write down what happened that night before they make me forget it. Quill will write that the King struck a bargain and paid nothing. Quill was not there.

We walked the drowned road to the bottom of the Hollow. I had expected monsters. They sent five lords in grey to meet us, and they bowed, and one of them asked the King, in our own tongue, why his people had been ringing bells at them for four hundred years.

He answered them honestly. That was the whole of his cunning. By the end of the night they had a truce, and at seventeen past three the Hollow reached up and took the Grey Host, every man, in the space of one bell. That was the miracle. It was a signature.

Notebook VII: On the Lost

Corvin Hale

When the Choir takes someone, something must fill the hole, or the family will come looking, and looking is dangerous. So the Hollow sends back a shape.

The shape knows everything the person knew. It is almost right. But it wears the body the way you would wear another man's glove, and it gets the hands wrong: it favors the wrong one. It does not like bells, because a bell calls it home. And when it believes itself alone, it turns and faces the wall, toward wherever the Hollow is seeping in nearest. It is always a little damp.

I have met six. They were all very polite. One of them asked me, sadly, if I knew where she had gone.

Notebook VIII: On Thin Places

Corvin Hale

The Crack in the Deep will not stay where it is. A door like that drifts toward warmth, and sooner or later it will slide to whichever thin place lies nearest the brightest keep in the land. There are seven thin places I know of.

THE DROWNED CHAPEL, under the sea at Gull's Rest. THE BELLFOUNDERS' MINE in Frostmarch, where Maelis dug her bronze. KING'S BARROW in the Vale, under the royal mound. THE SALTGLASS GROTTO, in the Emberwaste salt flats.

FROSTVEIN HOLLOW, an ice cave in the north. THE SUNKEN QUARRY, the flooded pit west of Millbrook. THE WITCHROOT CAVES, under Blackfen. Whoever finds the door again: it will look like a crack in a cave wall, nothing more, until you are close enough to hear it breathing.

Notebook IX: The Overthrow

Corvin Hale

It is done, and I helped them do the last of it, and I will not be forgiven and should not be.

The lords came for him on a third night, when he walked the walls alone. The princess was with them. He did not draw his sword. He said: 'If you break it, little Ash, they will come, and they will be right to.' They put him through the Crack alive. Then they rang every bell in Aldmere.

The Hollow came up through every well and lake in the kingdom. At Bellhollow they made me ring the Founding Bell against them. It did not only drive them back. It tore every thin place shut at once and left a single wound in the rock, somewhere, like the scar where a net is cut. They are behind it now. So is he.

Notebook X: The Last Page

Corvin Hale

They will burn me tomorrow for refusing to forget him. Let them. I would rather be ash than a liar.

Whoever reads this, understand the shape of it. We broke the truce, not they. Every army that marches on a keep on the third night is a debt being collected by a people who can no longer come and collect it themselves. And the Gate will not hold forever. A scar is weaker than skin. Whatever leaks through it is them, working at the stitches.

There will be someone leading them by now. Grief makes kings quickly. I do not know who, and I am afraid to guess. But the truce was sworn on their crown, and a thing sworn can be sworn again. If you go down there with a sword and nothing else, you will only be the next chapter of the same war. Someone must

COLLECTION IV

The Surveyor's Field Notes

Brother Fennick found where the Gate wandered to, and hid the answer across six notebooks.

1. Field Notes I: Water
2. Field Notes II: Bells
3. Field Notes III: Hands
4. Field Notes IV: Cold
5. Field Notes V: Salt
6. Field Notes VI: Roots
7. Fennick's Last Report

Field Notes I: Water

Brother Ide Fennick, Surveyor of the Gate

The Grandmaster has sent me to find where the Gate has wandered. I have found it. I will not write where. If these notes fall into the wrong hands I will not hand them the door. Instead I write in six books one thing I saw there, so a patient reader can follow, and an impatient one cannot.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

First book done. My boots are still wet from the last site, or dry, depending on which you are asking about, and I will not tell you which.

Field Notes II: Bells

Brother Ide Fennick

The second thing I saw. Remember, Brother, that I visited all seven places, and wrote about one.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

I am told the bells used to be rung to keep the Hollow quiet. I wonder now if they did the opposite.

Field Notes III: Hands

Brother Ide Fennick

Third. I have started to hear something when I sleep. Not words. A tune.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

I measured the crack itself: four men tall and narrow as a door. It breathes. I am not being poetic. The air goes in and out of it.

Field Notes IV: Cold

Brother Ide Fennick

Fourth. The tune is louder. I have been humming it without meaning to.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

The Grandmaster's letter came today asking for my report. I will send these notebooks instead, one at a time, by six different roads.

Field Notes V: Salt

Brother Ide Fennick

Fifth. I dreamed I was in a village where everyone faced the walls. I woke up facing the wall of my tent.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

One more book and you will have all I can give you. Rule out what cannot be true. What is left is the door.

Field Notes VI: Roots

Brother Ide Fennick

Sixth and last. My left hand writes better than my right now. I do not remember learning that.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

That is everything. I have written down six things that are true of the door, and nothing that is true of the other six places. Find the one place where all six are true at once.

Fennick's Last Report

Brother Ide Fennick (written with the wrong hand)

Grandmaster. I have sent you six notebooks by six roads. I hope at least one arrived. I am going back to the door. I need to hear the end of the tune.

If you are not the Grandmaster, and you have all six: go to your Library and name the place. Do not go there first. If you name it wrong you will spend days digging at the wrong cave while it laughs at you.

And when you stand in front of it, do not answer the voice that asks for his daughter.

COLLECTION V

The Lighthouse Letters

Three hundred years of letters from a lighthouse keeper to his drowned wife, in their private cipher.

1. Letter to Annet (the first)
2. Letter to Annet (the second)
3. Letter to Annet (the third)
4. Letter to Annet (the fourth)
5. Letter to Annet (the fifth)
6. Letter to Annet (the sixth)
7. Letter to Annet (the seventh)
8. Letter to Annet (the last)

Letter to Annet (the first)

Elias Marrow, Keeper of the Light at Gull's Rest

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

My Annet. It has been a week. Everyone says I should stop writing to you, so I am writing to you to tell you that.

The night the sea went out you ran down to the strand with half the village to see the seabed. The Grey Host's ships were lying on the sand like dead whales. You waved to me up in the lamp room. And then the sea came back all at once, and I could not see your lantern any more.

I keep the lamp lit every night so you can find the shore. Come home.

Letter to Annet (the second)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. A year. The lamp has not gone out once.

I hear singing on the third night now, very faint, coming up through the water. Hundreds of voices. One of them is yours. I would know it anywhere, you always sang a little sharp.

The new priest says it is the wind in the rocks. The new priest has not been married.

Letter to Annet (the third)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. I have been watching the tides as if they were your face.

Once a month, on the night the moon is dark, the sea goes out further than it ever does otherwise, almost as far as it did the night you went. When it does, the tower of the old chapel of Saint Brannoc shows above the water, and I can see the chapel door.

The door is open. It was not open before.

Letter to Annet (the fourth)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. Men came from the new Order with a book and wrote in the parish register that you died of a fever in the spring.

You did not die of a fever. You went down to the strand on the night the sea went out, the night the war ended, and the sea took you. I told them so. They said it would be better for everyone if it was a fever.

I scratched it out after they left. They wrote it in again. I have stopped going to the chapel.

Letter to Annet (the fifth)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. There is a thing I saw the morning after you went, and I have told no one.

A man walked up out of the sea, near dawn, as the bells were still shaking. He was soaked to the bone and wore a crown, and he did not shiver at all. He asked me the way to Crownhold, very politely. He was holding his sword in his left hand.

I pointed the way and he went. I think I have seen his face on coins. I think I am not supposed to say so.

Letter to Annet (the sixth)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. You came to the window last night.

You were standing on the water under the lamp room, in your wedding dress, and your hair was full of weed, and you were smiling. You said: 'Elias, stop lighting the lamp. It is how they find the shore.'

I did not stop. I cannot stop. If I stop, you will not find me.

Letter to Annet (the seventh)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. I worked out where you are.

Chapel of Saint Brannoc, under the sea. Go in by the open door. Third pew from the drowned altar. Under the floor stone carved with a gull. That is where the water is coldest, and where the singing is loudest. That is where you are.

I will go when the moon is dark and the sea goes out.

Letter to Annet (the last)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. I am going down to you tonight. I have left the lamp lit.

If anyone finds this: I have been keeping this light for three hundred years, and I am tired, and I do not think I have aged a day. I think I may have gone down with her that night and only my habit came back up.

Do not put the lamp out until she is free. Free her first. Then put it out. Then let me go.

COLLECTION VI

The Sung Verses

Hymns of the Choir, written backward. Reading them is not good for you.

1. Hymn of the Held Ground
2. The Toll
3. Canticle of the Lantern Keeps
4. Psalm of the Wrong Hand
5. Litany of the Oathbreakers
6. The Mercy of the Bell
7. The Name We Were
8. Hymn for the Coming Crown

Hymn of the Held Ground

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Sing of the wall that does not fall. Sing of the banner that does not move. Sing of the ones who will not leave. They are warm, they are warm, they are warm.

We were warm once. We held ground once. We remember holding. We do not remember our hands.

Every keep is a lantern. Every lantern is a meal. Every meal is a voice for the song.

The Toll

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

One night we sleep. One night we wake. The third night is ours. It was sworn.

On the third night we may not come, so we call. We call to the angry and the empty. We call to the dead who are still walking and the living who are already dead. They hear. They march. They do not know why.

They are not ours. They are only answering. We are the bell. They are the echo.

Canticle of the Lantern Keeps

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

We see you. We see your walls go up. We see your banner. We see the people you bring inside. Brighter. Brighter. Brighter.

When you win, you burn brighter still. We are grateful. We send more.

Little lantern, little keep, you do not know that every stone you lay is a word in our song.

Psalm of the Wrong Hand

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

We send back the shape so no one will come looking.
The shape knows the name. The shape knows the bread.
The shape knows the way to the bed.

But the shape wears the body badly. Its good hand is your wrong hand. Its door is your wall. Its silence is your bell.
And it never quite dries.

Do not ring for the shape. If you ring, it comes home. If it comes home, it brings company.

Litany of the Oathbreakers

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Hear the names of those who wronged us. Maelis, who rang us out of the marsh where the worlds first touched. The daughter, who broke what her father swore. The grey knights, who burned the proof.

Hear the name of the one who kept faith. We named him ourselves: Morvane. The name he had before, you burned, and we will not give it back to you.

He sits with us now. He taught us your walls. He taught us your nights. When the Gate is wide enough he will walk up through it first, and he will be so glad to be home.

The Mercy of the Bell

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Do not be afraid of the bell. The bell is mercy. The bell gathers the lost and brings them home.

No one is cold in the song. No one is alone in the song. No one is forgotten in the song, because no one is anyone in the song.

Come down. Come home. It is warm under the water.

The Name We Were

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Before your bells there was a marsh where our world ran aground on yours. We came up through the reeds as guests. Your people called the place Hallowmere, the mere where the Hollow shows, and for a while it was the name of a kingdom, and it was both of ours.

A queen came with a bell. She rang us out, and named what was left Aldmere, and for four hundred years your bells said: go away, go away, go away.

One of yours came down and spoke to us as people. We remember. Say the old name and we will know that you remember too. Hallowmere. Hallowmere. It was both of ours.

Hymn for the Coming Crown

The Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

A lantern brighter than the rest. A shard of the bell breaks loose to find it. A hand that takes it hears us. A hand that gives it away is watched by those who shut the door.

Either way, little lantern, you are coming down to us. Either way the road ends at the throne.

We will sing your name when you arrive. We are learning it already.

COLLECTION VII

Testimonies of the Lost Days

Statements, notices and confessions from ordinary people. Some of them are lying, and one is not a person.

1. Statement of Reeve Anselm Tock
2. What Happened to Tobin
3. Notice to the People of Millbrook
4. Grandmother Ashby's Account
5. Report of Sir Gerrit the Pale
6. Parish Register of Gull's Rest
7. Town Record of Sunscar
8. Testimony of Old Mag
9. Statement of a Returned Woman
10. What the Farmer Heard

Statement of Reeve Anselm Tock

Anselm Tock, Reeve of Millbrook

I, Anselm Tock, Reeve of Millbrook, make this statement freely. On the night of the first toll after the war, I heard the bell beneath the well. It began at seventeen minutes past three.

I stopped every clock in Millbrook at that minute. If the minute never ends, the toll never finishes, and the bell never finishes opening. That is my reasoning. I stand by it.

There are six clocks in Millbrook. Only one of them is the clock I stopped first, and that is the one that matters. The others I set to match. Some of them have drifted since. Some of the villagers will lie to you about which is which, because they do not want the night to end. They are afraid of what the morning will show them.

What Happened to Tobin

Wren Ashby, aged nine (now Sister Wren)

My brother Tobin went out to the well on the third night and did not come back till morning. Mam said he was just tired.

He is not just tired. He eats with his left hand now. He used to sing in the chapel and now he will not go in when the bell rings. At night I woke up and he was standing in the corner facing the wall and humming.

I asked him what he was humming. He turned round and smiled at me and said 'the way home'. He smiled with the wrong side of his mouth.

Notice to the People of Millbrook

The Reeve's Office (after Tock)

BY ORDER OF THE REEVE. Persons who go missing for a night and come home are NOT to be troubled. They are the same people as before. They are only tired.

There is no cause for alarm. Tales of 'wrong hands' and 'humming' are idle talk, and anyone spreading them will be fined two silver.

Ring no bells after dark. This is for the comfort of the tired, and for no other reason.

Grandmother Ashby's Account

Hild Ashby of Rimehold, as told to her granddaughter Sigrun

Half the village walked out onto the lake that night. Not running, not afraid. Walking, in their nightclothes, in a line, humming.

I followed their footprints in the morning. They go out to the middle of the lake, all of them together, and they stop. No hole in the ice. No bodies. Just footprints that stop.

Carved on the shrine by the lake is a full moon. My grandmother always said: 'it is the other one you want, Hild.' I never knew what she meant.

Report of Sir Gerrit the Pale

Sir Gerrit, Master of Hounds of the Ashen Gate

Grandmaster: I have run down eleven of the mage's twelve students. The twelfth fled onto the Rimehold lake with a satchel of books.

She went to the shrine and waited. There was no moon in the sky that night, but when I looked down at the ice there was a moon in it, full and white. Then the ice opened like a door, and she went down into it, and it closed.

I mean to wait for it to open again and follow her. If I do not report again, assume I have.

Parish Register of Gull's Rest

The Chapel of Gull's Rest

Deaths this spring: Joss Penrow, fisherman, drowned. Mary Kettle, of age. Annet Marrow, wife of Elias the lamp-keeper, of a fever.

(The entry for Annet Marrow has been scratched out, and written in again in a different hand, and scratched out again, and written in again. The last time it was written, someone pressed so hard the nib went through the page.)

Deaths this summer: none. The sea has been very calm.

Town Record of Sunscar

The Wardens of Sunscar

In the year after the war, the faces of all the statues in Sunscar were worn away by the desert wind, in a single summer. This is well known and not remarkable.

The fragments were swept up and the statues left as they are, as a lesson in the patience of the desert.

Visitors are asked not to search for the fragments. There are no fragments. The wind took them.

Testimony of Old Mag

Magda Venn of Mirelight

My name is Magda Venn. I am three hundred and eleven years old. I was the mage Corvin's last apprentice, and I was twelve when they burned him.

I ran into the swamp. The Order sent a man with hounds after Corvin's students. He got the others. He did not get me, because the swamp hid me, and something under the swamp kept me. I do not age. I do not want to know why.

The people of Mirelight think I am a mad old woman who claims to be three hundred. They are half right.

Statement of a Returned Woman

Unsigned (the ink is still wet, and always will be)

I am Dora Penrow. I went to the well. I came back. I am Dora Penrow.

I know the name of the dog and the name of the baby and where the bread is kept. I know all of it. Why does the dog not know me.

Sometimes I stand facing the wall because that is where the door is. The door is not there. I wait anyway. Someone is coming to take me home.

What the Farmer Heard

Hobb Carrow, farmer (recent)

Something fell out of the sky three nights ago, after the raiders were beaten off at the new keep up the hill. A pale light, humming. It landed in my turnips.

It whispered names. None I know. Tamsin Reed. Aldo Kettle. Little Jory Fenn. I asked around. Nobody by those names lives anywhere near. I keep hearing them anyway.

A knight came in the morning asking for it. By then it was gone. He looked frightened. Knights should not look frightened.

COLLECTION VIII

The Fallen

The last words of the great enemies of the land, taken from them when they fell.

1. The Reeve's Ledger
2. The Huntsman's Tally
3. Annet's Prayer
4. The Seneschal's Confession
5. The Mother's Lullaby
6. Vorlund's Oath
7. The Last Testament

The Reeve's Ledger

Anselm Tock, the Clockwork Reeve

Day 1 of the minute. The clocks are stopped. The bell is quiet. It worked.

Day 40 of the minute. The bell is not quiet. It is only very slow. Every year the minute moves a hair. I have begun replacing my own parts with clockwork, so I can stay awake to hold it.

Day 109,500 of the minute. I am mostly gears now. When someone finally stops me, the minute will end, the bell will finish its stroke, and the well will open. I am sorry. I held it as long as I could.

The Huntsman's Tally

Sir Gerrit, the Pale Huntsman

Eleven notches for eleven students. The twelfth I followed down through the ice.

Below the ice there is a town. It is not Rimehold. It is no town of ours at all: black water in the streets, leaning towers, a sky with its own moon. And the half of Rimehold who walked out onto the lake are standing in its square, facing a wall, humming. The twelfth student was with them. She smiled at me. Then the hounds turned on me.

I have been hunting my way back up ever since. I do not remember what I was hunting when I started.

Annet's Prayer

Annet Marrow, the Drowned Bride

Saint Brannoc, who loved the sea, let him put the lamp out.

Every night he lights it, and every night the Choir sees the shore by it, and sends something up the beach. He thinks he is guiding me home. He is guiding them.

I am not angry with him. I was never angry with him. Tell him to put it out, and then tell him I am waiting, and then let him come.

The Seneschal's Confession

Lord Hadrian Sorrel, the Ash Seneschal

It was not the wind. I did it. The Regent asked the Order to remove her father's face from every statue in Aldmere, and I asked to do Sunscar myself, because I had served him, and I wanted the last hands on his face to be gentle ones.

I took the faces off one by one with a mason's chisel. I scattered the fragments so they could not be put back. When I finished the last one, I put my hand to my own face and it was smooth.

Whoever rebuilds his face, rebuild mine too, if you can. I would like to be able to weep for him.

The Mother's Lullaby

The Mother of Changelings

Hush, hush, I make you a shape. A shape for the bed you left. A shape for the door you went out of. A shape so no one comes looking.

I am not cruel. I am tidy. The Choir takes and I fill the hole. If I did not, they would come down after you with torches and bells, and then the Choir would have them too.

Every changeling is my child. Every child is a hole with a shape in it. Hush now. Face the wall. That is where the door is.

Vorlund's Oath

Vorlund, last Thane of the Grey Host, the Warlord King

I was Thane of the Ice Isles. I led the Grey Host. Our priests heard a bell under the ice, and a voice in it that said: cut down the bells of Aldmere and the world is yours. So we came for them.

The voice sold us. One night their king went below, and before dawn the thing that had called us reached up and took my whole army in one stroke, as its part of a bargain. They kept me. They put a splinter of their crown in my brow so that I would hear them.

Every third night Morvane tells me where to march. I have never seen him. I know the voice. I have led your enemies for three hundred years and never once chosen where to go. Kill me, and see if they let me stay dead.

The Last Testament

Morvane, the Voice Below, who was Oswin, last King of Aldmere

So you know me now. Morvane is the name they gave me. There is no portrait of me left above, so I will tell you the other: I was Oswin. I made a peace, and my daughter threw me down a hole for it.

They took me in. I was the only one of yours who had ever kept his word to them, so they crowned me and renamed me, and I have spent three hundred years collecting what was owed. Every third night. Every keep. I taught them your walls. I am not sorry. I am very tired.

The crown is theirs, not mine. It should have killed me. They put it on me themselves and held me while it took the king out of me, and that is the only way it ever fit one of ours. It will kill you, unless you have the art: it sits only on one who can hear the whole of the Hollow at once and not break. Take what you have won back up into the sun, and leave the seat empty for whoever can bear it. Or do the thing I could not make my own child do, and keep the truce. Tell Edda the door was well made. Tell her I knocked every third night.



Here the Library ends.

SAY THE OLD NAME.